Ukraine's Military Faces Limits on Starlink Satellite Service

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Ukraine's military has lost some access to Starlink, a **satellite** internet system it has relied on during its war with Russia, according to Ukrainian officials.

Starlink is run by Elon Musk's company SpaceX. It uses more than 11,000 **satellites** in low **orbit** around Earth to deliver fast internet connections. A more secure military version is called Starshield. Shortly after Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022, a Ukrainian leader asked Musk to turn Starlink on in the country, and Musk soon did.

It is not clear why the new **restrictions** were put in place. On Wednesday, Musk wrote on the social media site X that Starshield systems are owned and controlled by the U.S. government. He said any limits would have been ordered by the U.S. military and, in the end, the president. CBC News reported that the U.S. government had not responded so far. The **restrictions** come as President Donald Trump has criticized Ukraine's president, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, for attacks on Russian oil **refineries**, which Trump blames for high oil prices.

According to Serhii Beskrestnov, a technology adviser to Zelenskyy, Ukraine uses the network for drone missions, **air defense** and delivering supplies to the front line. He said the **restrictions** included a speed limit on Starlink equipment mounted on drones.

Experts explained why the system matters. Thomas Withington of the Royal United Services Institute called it "an incredibly capable communication system." He said it lets soldiers near the front talk with commanders hundreds of kilometers away, and that it is very hard for enemies to **jam**, or block. Renard Sexton, a professor at Emory University, said Starlink was crucial in helping Ukraine push back against Russia's first invasion in 2022.

Word Treasure

satellite -- A satellite is a machine sent into space to circle Earth, often to send signals.

orbit -- An orbit is the curved path an object follows as it travels around a planet.

restrictions -- Restrictions are rules or limits that stop something from being used fully.

refineries -- Refineries are factories that turn crude oil into fuels such as gasoline and diesel.

air defense -- Air defense is the equipment and work used to protect an area from attacks from the sky.

jam -- To jam a signal means to block it so messages cannot get through.

Background you need

Starlink is a network of many small satellites that orbit close to Earth and beam internet signals to dishes on the ground.

Because the signals come from space, Starlink can work in places where phone towers and cables have been damaged, which is why it became important during the war in Ukraine.

Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022, and Ukraine's military has used Starlink to communicate across long distances.

Starshield is a more secure version of the network built for government and military use, and Elon Musk says it is controlled by the U.S. government.

Break it down

LEAD: Ukraine's military has lost some access to Starlink, Ukrainian officials say.

BACKGROUND: Starlink, run by SpaceX, uses more than 11,000 satellites; Starshield is the military version

KEY EVENT: Unclear restrictions on the service

+- WHO: Elon Musk says Starshield is controlled by the U.S. government and limits would come from the military and president

+- CONTEXT: President Trump has criticized Ukraine's attacks on Russian oil refineries

+- DETAIL: A speed limit on Starlink equipment on drones, says adviser Serhii Beskrestnov

EVIDENCE: Experts Thomas Withington and Renard Sexton explain why the system matters

OPEN QUESTION: The U.S. government had not responded about why the limits were imposed.

Why it matters

The story shows how a private company's technology has become important in a war, and raises questions about who controls it and why its use was limited.

Test what you remember

1. What has Ukraine's military lost some access to?

- (A) Its radio towers
- (B) Its supply trucks
- (C) Starlink satellite internet
- (D) A U.S. weather service

2. Which company runs Starlink?

- (A) Ukraine's army
- (B) NASA
- (C) CBC News
- (D) SpaceX

3. What did Elon Musk say about Starshield on Wednesday?

- (A) It was only used for video games
- (B) It is owned and controlled by the U.S. government
- (C) It would shut down forever
- (D) It belongs to Russia

4. About how many satellites does Starlink use?

- (A) More than 11,000
- (B) About 100
- (C) About 2,022
- (D) Exactly 50

5. According to Serhii Beskrestnov, what did the restrictions include?

- (A) A speed limit on Starlink equipment mounted on drones
- (B) Turning off all satellites
- (C) Higher prices for subscribers
- (D) A ban on phone calls

6. Why did Thomas Withington say Starlink is useful?

- (A) It works only at night
- (B) It is cheap to build
- (C) It lets soldiers talk with faraway commanders and is hard to jam
- (D) It replaces airplanes

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Elon Musk: He says Starshield is owned and controlled by the U.S. government, so any limits would have been ordered by the U.S. military and the president.

2. Ukrainian officials: They say the military has lost some access, and an adviser says the limits include a speed limit for drone-mounted equipment.

3. Military experts: Thomas Withington and Renard Sexton say Starlink has been a very valuable, hard-to-jam communication system for Ukraine.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):